lead missions in Europe, Africa and Asia. Many of our gallant soldiers laid down their lives; some of them have been decorated with the highest gallantry awards. We have created a training facility for UN peacekeepers at New Delhi, which again has been in great demand in our region. It trains leaders as well as observers for UN assignments. Besides that, all units assigned UN missions are put through a comprehensive training programme for four weeks, and some persons from the core group are also imparted language skills.

From the global point of view, as the dust began to settle after the cataclysmic break-up of the USSR in 1990, it appeared that a unipolar world had emerged, with the USA as the most powerful nation on earth.

However, during the past two decades, we have witnessed the diffusion of political, military and economic power, with the rise of China, the European Union, Japan, Russia, India, and Brazil. The US no longer believes that it can go it alone or that its best interests would be served by being in the lead role in every situation. Therefore, a 'defining strategic partnership' between the two largest democracies of the world, as emphatically stated by President Barak Obama during his November 2010 visit to India, assumes great importance. Indo-US relations are gaining a momentum of their own. This is a golden opportunity for us to forge a meaningful long-term relationship with America which, in the words of President Obama, 'will be indispensable in shaping the twenty-first century'. With shared democratic values and more convergence in views than differences, our mutually beneficial partnership portends well for peace and stability in the world.

These very heartwarming and welcome sentiments are in stark contrast to the perceptions in America about our country during the Cold War period. I recollect reading and rereading an international weekly magazine that had done a cover story on 'Democracy' in the late 1970s. India was not mentioned even once in that story, leaving all right-thinking Indians aghast. From 'not figuring' on the